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The Hellenistic Age: Aristotle, the Epicureans, and the Stoics

Aristotle (385–322): His Philosophical Development

Vico's warning against the glorification of antiquity tends to fall on deaf ears when the full sweep of Aristotle's achievement presents itself. Here is a philosopher-scientist who has had a more direct and enduring effect on more departments of scholarship than any other single figure. More than one reverent historian has described him as the last person to have known everything that was known in his own time.

What we know of his life is spotty. He was a devoted student of Plato's for some twenty years, perhaps from the founding of the Academy (367 B.C.) until the master's death (347), although he participates in only one of the dialogues, the *Parmenides*. He was born in Stageirus, on the eastern edge of the Chalcidice, and was of Ionian heritage. His father was personal physician to the Macedonian king, Amyntas II, father of Philip II and grandfather of Alexander the Great. Thus, a measure of the prestige enjoyed by the Academy can be gleaned from the fact that a family of means and connections would send their seventeen-year-old son there for instruction.

Following Werner Jaeger, it is customary to separate Aristotle's philosophical development into three stages.¹ In the first, he is a Platonist to the core, the author of now lost dialogues, the student of the "ideas." The next phase of his life comes when the direction of the Academy falls to Plato's cousin, Speusippus, in 347. This was either the cause or a mere coincidence attending Aristotle's departure from Athens. During the following twelve years (347–335), his busy life included his marriage to Pythias, his teaching of Alexander (334–336), his direction of the group of Platonists at Assos, and what must have been a reassessment of his own position on basic philosophical and scientific questions. The third phase begins with the death of Philip II and the accession to power of Alexander (335). Now Aristotle returns to Athens, establishes his

own school, the Lyceum, and devotes the remaining thirteen years of his life to that body of thought posterity would call "Aristotelianism" (although the latter would come to include any number of features otherwise not visible in Aristotle's own surviving works). On the news of Alexander's death in 323 Aristotle retired to Chalcis in the Euboea, recognizing that the Athenians would now be free to express their fervent nationalism by attacking any and all Macedonian sympathizers. We are told that he left Athens so the city "would not sin against Philosophy a second time."

Indirect evidence suggests that Aristotle arrived at the Academy after the Platonic circle had completed the *Theaetetus* and while it was engaged in the *Parmenides*. Werner Jaeger has argued convincingly that it is unlikely the challenges offered by the Aristotele featured in this dialogue would have come from a teenager from Stageirus.² Indeed, though we do not have Aristotle's own early dialogues, we have considerable circumstantial evidence that they were consonant with the prevailing theories of the Academy. Several of them were, we may believe, merely updatings of older Platonic works (e.g., the *Eudemos* vis-à-vis Plato's *Phaedo* and the *Gryllus* vis-à-vis Plato's *Gorgias*).³ Among these earliest works, we do have fragments of the *Protrepticus* ("striving"),⁴ which, although not a dialogue, is nearly orthodox Platonism. It is in this work that we find a defense of Anaxagoras' commitment to "contemplate the heavens" and recourse to the authority of Pythagoras. The world of sense is respected, but the world of idea is proclaimed supreme:

Hence we should do all things for the sake of the goods that reside in man himself, and of these, that which is good in the body we should do for the sake of that which is good in the soul. . . . [W]isdom is the supreme end.⁵

[W]e ought either to pursue philosophy or bid farewell to life . . . because all other things seem to be but utter nonsense and folly.⁶

Mingled with his devotion to the soul and its ideas, however, are the subtle intimations of a coming revolution:

. . . if life is preferred and valued on account of sense-perception, and if sense-perception is a sort of knowledge. . . .⁷

It is clear that, on the whole, Aristotle's earliest period of intellectual commitment was as a Platonist. The revolution he initiated in his later years might be seen not so much as an attack on Platonism as it was a unique critical synthesis. It was quite common in the centuries following the death of Plato and Aristotle for philosophers to regard their two schools as complementary and compatible, not at all at odds at the most fundamental level:

Nonetheless, there are differences worth noting between the Aristotle of the missing dialogues and the Aristotle known through the surviving works of 335–322. First, the earliest Aristotle is a pupil in the Academy confronting the already traditional problems of philosophy, but through a medium and format not readily applicable to the Hellenistic Age. Aristotle, considering both his own interests and Alexander's commitment to spread and impose Greek culture throughout the empire, must have recognized that the dialectical method was less than useful. The materials prepared for instruction at his Lyceum would be lectures in scripted form, not the fruits of late-night colloquies.

Aristotle departed from Platonic tradition also in the very range and details of his inquiries. There can be no deeper study than what is found in Plato's dialogues, but they are often lacking in the substantive content now taken (thanks to Aristotle!) to be the essence of scientific and scholarly pursuit. This gap between general principles and factual information is one that Aristotle's teaching strived to fill. Where the Platonists of the *Republic* politely argued a constitution into being, Aristotle examined some 158 different and actual constitutions, analyzing their premises and the factual evidence standing in their support. Of this effort only *The Constitution of Athens* has turned up. The exacting study brought to bear on it by Aristotle and his students suggests how monumental an effort went into research on other constitutions. Again, where Timaeus in Plato's dialogue would content himself with an explanation of space perception based only on a "spurious kind of reason," Aristotle would devote entire books to the subjects of vision, touch, taste, sensory integration, and the senses of nonhuman animals.

Finally, the Platonists were too willing to dismiss all but abstractions as irrelevant. Neither Aristotle nor his contemporaries could share this luxury. Those rare passages in Aristotle that address Platonism in a contemptuous tone are invariably directed at the exclusionary elements of the Platonic program. This is hinted at in the two versions of Aristotle's *Metaphysics*: an earlier one in which the first-person plural is used in the discussion of ideas, and the later version in which the third-person plural is used.⁸ This grammatical shift is of significance. In the later version those who subscribe to a separate sphere of reality, the sphere of ideas, and who regard the sphere of appearance to be but a distortion of the truth, have become "they," where earlier they had been "we."

In his *Metaphysics*, Aristotle praised Socrates for developing inductive reasoning and for advancing the theory and the problem of universals.⁹ In the *Theaetetus* and the *Meno*, Socrates distinguished between perception of particular instances and general ideas, the latter of which cannot be received through perception. The word "cat" is illustrative. We can see a particular cat but we only know (cognitively) that it is a cat because it answers to the descrip-

Naturalism

tion given by our general idea of cat. In the simplest terms, the problem of universals is this: since no single cat can be so identified unless there is some supra-individual class (i.e., a universal) of which it is an instance, is the universal cat real? *13006*

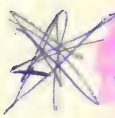
In later Scholastic philosophy, those who accorded real existence to such universals were known as *realists*, and those who insisted that terms such as "cat" were simply names given to particular things were dubbed "nominalists." Now, Socrates did not suggest that somewhere in the cosmos a perfected, four-legged, mewling ideal cat sits sipping ideal milk. He was not that sort of realist, at any rate. What he did suggest, however, was that true knowledge of what a cat is depends on the true idea of the cat as a universal; the *true form* of cat is not something any particular cat can match. Since any particular cat can be no more than an approximation to the ideal, our perceptual knowledge of cats can only be an approximation to true knowledge of cat. But perception will only be of the attribute and, unaided, will not discover the ideal. The ideal, of course, is the idea: that in which each particular instance shares but only shares imperfectly and incompletely.

On Aristotle's account, Socrates was credited with retaining the connection between a universal class and its perceptible instances, but he rebuked the later Platonists for dissolving this connection:

Socrates did not make the universals or the definitions exist apart; they, however, gave them separate existence, and this was the kind of thing they called Ideas.¹⁰

Aristotle would resist such idealistic notions in attempting to ground his own system of philosophy in the observable facts of animal and inanimate nature.

Aristotle on the Soul

 Aristotle's most sustained discussion of human and nonhuman psychological processes is developed in the treatise *On the Soul* (*De Anima*), a treatise whose conjectures are intended to be fully "compatible with experience" (402b). What is to be avoided is a method of inquiry that is merely based on argument (*dialectikos*), another sign of his movement away from the traditions of the Academy.

In the very first chapter of the treatise he identifies the emotions (anger, courage, appetite) and the sensations as conditions of the soul and insists that they can only exist through the medium of a body. All such "affections" of the soul are to be conceived as "materialized formulable essences," which is sometimes more transparently translated as "properties derived from the body." The full sentence in which the thought is included is translated as,

*properties ~~are~~
from the body*

"Clearly it follows from this that the soul's empathic feelings are to be understood as properties deriving from the material body" (*De Anima*, Book I, Ch. I, 403a; 24–25). Simply stated, Aristotle is insisting that an understanding of human and animal psychology depends upon and is informed by our knowledge of the material (biological) conditions of life.

The essentially physiological character of his psychology appears frequently throughout his works, including those that are not particularly concerned with psychological matters. In his *Physics*, for example, he argues that the affairs of the soul are brought about "by alterations of something in the body" (248a). In the same work he opposes the Platonic notion of intellectual processes as turbulent and offers, instead, the theory of quiescence: perception and intellect, if they are to be precise and organized, require that the soul approach a condition of rest. He attributes the inferiority of perception on the part of children and the aged to a "great amount of restlessness," and all such deficits are to be explained as some kind of alteration "of something in the body."¹¹ In his treatise on sleep and dreams (*De Somniis*) he again accounts for the phenomena by appealing to sensory-biological processes and offers the surprisingly modern hypothesis that dreams are the result of our conscious experiences and our emotions.¹² Even that most complex of psychological features, memory, is treated in purely biological terms. In *De Memoria et Reminiscencia* (*On Memory and Reminiscence*), which we will note again shortly, he discusses recollection as the "searching for an image in a corporeal substrate" (453a) and again explains the memory deficiencies of children, the aged, and the diseased in terms of biological anomalies.

When we study the philosophers before Aristotle, we can uncover, here and there, a psychological orientation that is naturalistic and biological in tone. This is certainly true of several of the pre-Socratics and it is also true of particular passages in the *Timaeus*. However, no predecessor could lay equal claim to the title of physiological psychologist. Aristotle was the first to specify the domain embracing the subject matter of psychology and, within that domain, to frame explanations in terms of the presumed biology of organisms. That the entire body of Aristotelian psychology, not to mention philosophy, does not fit into a radical materialistic mold is clear; the philosopher himself goes to some lengths to make it clear. But on the narrower issues of learning, memory, sleep and dreams, routine perceptions, animal behavior, emotion, and motivation, Aristotle's approach is naturalistic, physiological, and empirical.

At the same time, he rejected the extreme materialism of Democritus, who judged soul and mind (*nous*) to be the same and insisted that both were reducible to atoms (*On the Soul: De Anima*, 405a). At 407b he dismisses the Platonic theory of soul-as-harmony or as proportion, since such hypothesized harmonies are not evident in biological systems. And at 408b he specifically distin-

everything
rooted in phys.
(no soul).

essence - being - what is
existence - becoming - This is

guishes soul from mind, the latter dwelling somehow within the soul but, unlike the soul, being imperishable. That mind itself is not merely certain mental faculties is clear from his treatment of the process of senility:

[I]n old age the activity of the mind or intellectual apprehension declines only through the decay of some other inward part; mind itself is impassible. (408b)

Aristotle was not satisfied with any of the traditional theories of the soul, and he devoted Book I to a critique of them. He concluded by attributing their deficiencies to the error of believing that there is only one function of the soul. He, on the contrary, noted that biological systems exist in varying degrees of complexity and suggested that for each essential function there must be a corresponding psychic (i.e., motive) principle. The functions identified by Aristotle were the nutritive, the perceptive, the locomotor, and, in human beings alone, a "universalizing" faculty (*epistemonikon*) by which abstract principles can be comprehended. Any animal possessing an advanced function (e.g., intellect) will also have the less advanced functions (perception, locomotion, and nutrition). Each of these functions may express itself in one faculty or in a variety of faculties. Perception may, for example, be limited to touch, or all five senses may be well developed (Book II, Ch. 3). Even in the case of rationality, there may be only mere imagination or one may also possess the powers of calculation as well.

When Aristotle begins his *Metaphysics* with the observation that "all men by nature desire to know" and adds immediately that an example of this "is the delight they take in their senses," we begin to see the importance that will be attached to perceptual modes of knowing. We learn in the treatise *On the Soul* that sensation may be taken as part of the essential definition of "animal" in that every member of the animal kingdom is presumed to have sensory experiences. This is a major feature of Aristotle's general psychology. Nature does nothing without a purpose; animals of all kinds have special sensory organs; animals of all kinds must have the experiences such organs are clearly designed to mediate.

The perceptual theory developed by Aristotle emphasizes sensory integration, a process which is itself not sensory. Consider a cup of coffee. It is a hot, lightly sweetened, dark brown, liquid. The various specialized sensory organs respond respectively to each of these attributes: the temperature, taste, color and consistency. But the *experience* is not of separate attributes. Rather, there is a whole, fully integrated experience such that coffee will be distinguished from any number of other stimuli that also happen to be dark, hot, sweet liquids. So, in addition to the "five senses" delineated by Aristotle, there is also in his theory a *common sense* (*koine aisthesis*, *sensus communis*). This latter is not to be taken as itself a sense but as some process common to all the senses,

by which experiences are forged out of the separate contributions from the different sense organs.

After reviewing the general and special character of the five senses in *On the Soul* (Book II), Aristotle concerns himself with the mind and with the problem of how informed thought ever occurs in the first place if, indeed, it is not native, as the theory of Ideas supposed. His solution was to distinguish the actual from the potential: mind has the potential for thought, but for this to be actualized, it must be acted upon by the world. In a sentence that might have come from John Locke in the seventeenth century, Aristotle describes the mind prior to the experience and learning thus:

What it thinks must be in it just as characters may be said to be on a writing tablet on which as yet nothing actually stands written: this is exactly what happens with mind. (429b–430a)

On this account, the mind is taken to be a collection of complex processes supplied with information via the senses from the outside world. Without such mechanisms and processes, there would be nothing for the perceptual-cognitive processes to work on. Thus, the external world must cause physical responses in the sensory organs, these responses coming to depict or represent or stand as codes for the objects that cause them.

To this day scholars debate the extent of Aristotle's commitment to an essentially materialistic psychology. Was it in fact his position that all aspects of mind can finally be reduced to properties of the body such as those just cited? Much of *De Anima* certainly lends support to this conclusion, but there are telling exceptions, or at least suggestive ambiguities. The theory we assign to Aristotle will depend in part on how we understand his overall psychological system and also on how one translates several of the crucial terms he employed in his analysis. For example, when mind is discussed, such words as *nous*, *psyche*, and *epistemonikon* are used, but these are not synonyms. As is clear in *De Anima* and in his essays on natural history, Aristotle acknowledged the intellectual powers of the advanced species. His careful ethological observations led him to conclude, as Darwin would centuries later, that animals possess not only the "psychic" faculties of nutrition, reproduction, sensation, and motion, but also intelligence, feelings, and motives. What he reserved to human beings is that power or faculty that goes beyond the ability to learn and remember specific things; a faculty that rises to the ability to grasp universal concepts. This is evidence of reason proper (*nous*), the capacity for abstract rationality.

The term for this, *epistemonikon*, as it appears in *De Anima*, does not lend itself to easy translation. It is best rendered by the phrase, "that by which universals are grasped." Most interestingly, Aristotle asserts that the faculty in question does not move: "*epistemonikon ou kineitai*." Recalling that, on Aristotle's account, the very concept of matter is equated with motion, we are led

ability to grasp universals

to conclude that Aristotle is proposing a unique faculty of the soul; one possessed only by the human soul, and one that is incompatible with the very essence of matter. On this construction, it may be argued that Aristotle's theory of mind is not uniformly materialistic but *dualistic* at the highest level of rational activity. The issue remains controversial in Aristotle scholarship, as does the entire question of mind-body relationships, a question that will be confronted frequently in later chapters.

Aristotle on Learning and Memory



Except for the power of abstract rationality and the political and moral possibilities created by it, Aristotle's theories of human and nonhuman psychology are thoroughly naturalistic and biological. By "naturalistic" is meant that the assumed processes and principles governing psychological life are drawn from those operating in the biological world at large. Nothing "supernatural" or spiritual needs to be invoked to account for the phenomena. Aristotle's approach is also broadly ethological. What is to be explained is the manner in which the special physical design of creatures results in powers and functions that render them fit for the forms of life they characteristically live. Aristotle had a passion for observation and for classification. His overarching conception of nature was *teleological* in that he took the operations of the natural world to be aimed toward an end, or *telos*. Accordingly, his explanations of natural phenomena are generally framed in the language and logic of teleology. Animals and human beings do something *for the sake of* attaining something or *in order to* achieve a given goal. Similarly, the inanimate world is governed by laws and this very fact indicates a rational design and purpose. Various processes and functions are then understood according to the larger objectives or goals they serve.

The basic principles of learning are developed in one of Aristotle's already cited briefer works, *On Memory and Reminiscence*. In this essay Aristotle proposed repetition as the source of the strength of memories and proposed an associational mechanism by which items to be learned are held together. According to this theory, sensations set up certain motions within the soul. These subside in time, but, if they have been produced often enough, they can be re-created or, at least, a likeness of them can be re-created under comparable conditions in the future. Through repetition (by custom or habit), certain movements reliably follow or precede others. Our attempts to recall past events are only attempts to initiate the right *internal* events. This is why, when attempting to recall a sequence of events or objects, we must find the beginning of the appropriate series. When we do, an entire train of previously established associations is set in motion.

Aristotle advanced similar notions in his treatise on natural science (*Physics*), where he claims that all sentiments are finally traceable to sensory expe-

rience, going so far as to bring the moral sentiments themselves under the control of biological processes: “[A]ll moral excellence is concerned with bodily pleasures and pains” (247a). Thus, to the principle of associationism he adds a “pleasure principle” and thereby moves even his moral philosophy some distance from the traditional teachings of the Academy.

If all we possessed of Aristotle’s works were these treatises on the soul and on memory and reminiscence we would conclude that Aristotle’s theory of knowledge was empiricistic, his theory of learning associationistic, and his psychology essentially a form of behavioral biology. In a word, his psychology would be more or less contemporary. That this is not the case is established by his other works; his writings on logic, politics, ethics, and rhetoric. It is in these that we find a narrowing of the differences between his thought and Plato’s. We understand this aspect of his psychological theory by examining his own approach to the problem of knowledge and the knowable.

Aristotle on the Problem of Knowledge

Aristotle’s views in different treatises might make him seem inconsistent, for in some the emphasis is on experience and practice, in others on certain innate dispositions of the mind. The mission of the different treatises vary, however. In *De Anima*, for example, where it is claimed that, absent perception, there would be no knowledge at all (423a 3–10), Aristotle examines questions of an essentially psychological and psychobiological nature. Emphasis here is placed on perceptual knowledge. In his *Posterior Analytics*, however, the subject is scientific methodology. Whereas *De Anima* was devoted to natural processes, the latter is concerned with rules of evidence and argument. In *De Anima* attention is focused on the mechanisms of perception and learning, motivation and emotion. In *Posterior Analytics* we discover how a world of continuous changes can still be known with certainty.

Aristotle was well aware of the theory of fluxes advanced by Heraclitus. He knew also that the Academy had turned away from the senses in part because of this theory. Heraclitus had drawn attention to the ever-changing nature of the sensible world and argued for a relativistic attitude toward knowledge. The Socratics, however, found little merit in a life of study that produced no more than probabilities. So they looked behind the shifting world of Heraclitus, in which “no one enters the same river twice,” and discovered an “ideal” world of true forms and timeless mathematical relations.

In the *Posterior Analytics* Aristotle, too, attempts to locate abiding truths, but without subscribing to the received theories of the Academy. The position he takes instead begins to unfold toward the end of Book I:

Scientific knowledge is not possible through the act of perception. . . . one must perceive [things] and at a definite present place

and time: but that which is commensurately universal and true in all cases one cannot perceive. (87b)¹³

Now, to know "that which is commensurately universal and true," we must have certain standards of truth; standards of an essentially cognitive nature which allow us to organize the teeming and shifting facts of the physical world. That is, to be knowable, any physical object or event must tap or trigger some disposition or capacity of the mind which will give to the object or event features of a cognitively meaningful sort. Aristotle does not suggest that objects and events lack such features and that the mind invents them. Rather, he reasons that, to be knowable and known, these objects or events must have features somehow compatible with our very methods of knowing.

The features of the external world that can be known fall into ten categories¹⁴: (1) substance (according to which a thing is), (2) quality (the thing is white), (3) quantity (the white thing is three feet tall), (4) relation (the white thing is taller than the red thing), (5) place (the thing is there), (6) time (it was there yesterday), (7) position (it is standing in the corner), (8) state (that horse is shod), (9) action (he lanced the blister), and (10) affection (he was lanced, i.e., affected by the lance). These categories are applied to objects and events in order that we might classify, judge, compare, and locate them in space and time. They are the exhaustive categories by which any object or event can be known. Our perceptions are drawn from these categories, but are not the categories themselves. Indeed, were the categories not available prior to the act of perceiving, the objects of perception could not be classified according, for example, to time, place, quality, and the rest.

Aristotle's *Categories* was intended as an essay on logic. It does not purport to be a cognitive or psychological treatise. But even in the nonpsychological context in which Aristotle introduced them, the categories appear as mental dispositions, as principles according to which the world of matter and the world of knowledge merge, or at least enjoy the possibility of becoming integrated. The categories, however, are just that: categories of knowledge and not the scientific knowledge of that "which is commensurately universal and true."

It is only through what Aristotle called demonstration that such scientific knowledge becomes possible. As the term "demonstration" is employed in modern times, one might be tempted to think that Aristotle was advancing a purely empiricist method for obtaining true knowledge. This is not the case. Scientific knowledge, according to Aristotle, is *demonstrative* knowledge, not in the modern sense of experimental demonstration, but in the sense of rational or logical demonstration. At first blush, this position seems naive and characteristically ancient. But Aristotle was a tireless observer. Recall that he invented embryology by breaking open chicken eggs at different stages of development¹⁵ and that he established the shape of the earth by observing its shadow on the moon during eclipses.¹⁶ This was not a scholar who thought logic was a

substitute for the hard work of data-gathering. He was a gifted scientist, but he was a philosopher first, and as such he knew the difference between mere facts and demonstrative proofs.

The demonstrations Aristotle sought were grounded in the syllogistic modes of argumentation that he invented. The major premise in such an argument may be a law of nature, the minor premise, a fact of nature, and the conclusion, a necessary and demonstrated conclusion. Socrates is not said to be mortal merely because he died. He was known to be mortal while he lived. All persons are mortal and Socrates is a man. His death, on this account, is not a mere fact but a reasoned fact. Scientific knowledge, then, differs from perception by possessing the general (universal) principles which cover each and every particular instance.

The search for general laws is guided by another, central feature of Aristotle's theory of knowledge, its *teleological* character. To explain a phenomenon requires more than an identification of its antecedent cause. It requires the identification of its purpose, the very point of it, how it fits into the larger scheme of things. As he notes in his *Physics*,

It is absurd to suppose that purpose is not present because we do not observe the agent deliberating. Art does not deliberate. If this ship-building art were in the wood, it would produce the same results by nature. (*Physics*, 199b)

A physical-causal law cannot supply the full explanation of an event, for the causal law will not reveal the goal or plan or purpose to be realized by such lawful relationships. The most developed forms of human knowledge, then, are not confined to the scientific discovery of general laws but must go beyond these to an essentially *metaphysical* inquiry into reasons and purposes. Nature is not wasteful or pointless. The perfect orderliness of the heavens, the cyclical repetition of the seasons, the sequence of birth, growth, death and decay—the entire spectacle of nature conveys evidence of intelligent design. To explain anything completely, therefore, is to demonstrate how it fits into the grand design, and this calls for rational powers and methods that go beyond mere observation and reach universal principles.

Aristotle on Universals

The problem of the universals is an abiding one, “solved for all time” in every period of heightened philosophical speculation. Aristotle recognized that at least one form of it is merely semantic. (Since the thirteenth century, there have been philosophers contending that it is *only* semantics). Still, there are perceptual and cognitive dimensions of this problem, and a good many psychologists have staked their research and theories on the premise that the problem is more than a quibble about words. We can catch a glimmer of these cognitive and

perceptual elements by recalling the “universal cat” and determining just how one might go about teaching a three-year-old what a cat is.

Which animals should be called “cat,” “dog,” “wolf,” “lion,” etc.? The first and the simplest step is to bring in the family pet (a cat in this case), show it to the child and say “cat.” If this is done often, we have it on the very best authority that most children will learn to say “cat” anytime Tabby is displayed. But suppose this pet, a large gray one, is replaced by a Siamese. Will the child still say “cat”? If so, what was learned in the first place? In just a few years the same child will correctly identify all species of things despite great intraspecies differences in size, weight, color, temperament, and condition of health. The temptation, to be sure, is to attribute this successful performance to “stimulus generalization” (or induction, as Aristotle would say). But to generalize, the child must be in mental possession of some class or genus over which particular instances can be generalized. In other words, we run the risk of accounting for the performance by assuming the very “universal” we set out to eliminate.

To examine Aristotle’s approach to the problem we return to the *Posterior Analytics*, noting that the treatise begins with the declaration that “All instruction given or received by way of argument proceeds from preexistent knowledge” (99b–100a). It ends by addressing the sense in which knowledge is pre-existent. It is in the last chapter that Aristotle is found defending a nativistic theory of knowledge while seeming to reject it. First he scorns the nativistic account and then notes its compelling element:

Now it is strange if we possess them [states of knowledge] from birth for it means that we possess apprehensions more accurate than demonstration and fail to notice them. If on the other hand we acquire them and do not previously possess them, how could we apprehend and learn without a basis of pre-existent knowledge? (99b)

His only answer is that we do not have the knowledge at birth (thereby rejecting the nativistic theory of the Ideas), but we do have the capacity which is subsequently actualized through sense perception. And, while the senses themselves only detect the particular, their “content is universal” (100b), meaning that the mind is able to construct the universal from the data of experience. This is not orthodox Platonism by any means. Nonetheless, as a solution to the universal-particular aspect of the problem of knowledge, it is a compromise of the sort found in the *Theaetetus*.¹⁷ The senses do not convey knowledge per se, but they do convey that from which the reasoning can extract knowledge.

Aristotle and Platonism

It is clear both from his *Nicomachean Ethics*¹⁸ and from his *Rhetoric*¹⁹ that Aristotle envisaged human psychology as an evolving process. The Platonists were two-stage theorists in their treatment of the mind. This followed naturally

from the theory of Ideas. Since the Ideas are eternal and are present in the soul before birth, there are only two possible psychological states: one in which the individual is ignorant or mad, and one in which the person is enlightened. The senses contribute nothing to true knowledge, and so the mere experiences of a lifetime may find the old person as deeply in the cave as a child. Aristotle, forfeiting this binary conception and willing to accept the facts of everyday experience, advanced a dynamic theory of psychological development. As an associationist, he emphasized the role of practice and of rewards and punishments in learning and memory. As a social observer, he noted the differences among the young, the mature, and the aged as regards emotion, reason, courage, loyalty, and motivation. He knew that senility brought a decline of the faculties of perception and, consistent with his larger theory, that this necessarily produced changes in all spheres of intellectual endeavor. For Aristotle, growth and decay were the abiding correlates of the natural world, including human psychological prowess. While some rational principle may survive the grave, the individual soul and its more prosaic faculties would not.

The origins of reason were intermingled with our biological character, with the progression of our development, with the incessant commerce between mind and sense. Things that exist, exist for a purpose, and our purpose is to be, to become, to reason, and to die. That there is a "prime mover" responsible for setting the machinery in motion, a "cosmic reason" that has provided the overall plans and purposes of reality, was taken by Aristotle as established by the very order of the heavens. But with all this, Aristotle never conveyed the optimism of the Socrates of the *Phaedo*. For Aristotle, the affairs of man and of the prime mover are separated by an unrelenting breach. There is a plan, but one not likely to disclose itself fully. Reason evolves, experience teaches, and societies come and go. The best strategy is to live a rational form of life and realize those potentialities that are part of one's essential nature. Stoicism is on the horizon.

The Problem of Conduct

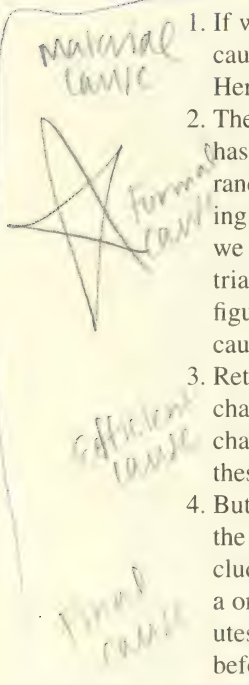
In Book VII of his *Politics*, Aristotle presents the principles of statecraft and those of individual excellence as virtually indistinguishable.²⁰ If Plato chose his Republic to serve as an enlarged model of the individual, Aristotle's attention to the individual is almost a preliminary stage leading to a discussion of the State. In his *Nicomachean Ethics*, man is first "a political creature whose nature is to live with others" (1169b). Every action of the individual (1094a) and the State (*Politics*, 1252a) aims at some good; otherwise, the action is involuntary and therefore to be judged either as accidental or performed in ignorance (*Nicomachean Ethics*, 1110b). 

This position, that all voluntary actions have some good as their goal, is but an instance of Aristotle's general teleological theory of nature. Over the cen-



turies this theory has fallen on hard times, often because of a failure to appreciate either Aristotle's statement of it or the facts of nature it was designed to explain. Since it is a central aspect of his social, political, and psychological speculations, it warrants further attention here.

In Book I of the *Posterior Analytics* (especially 73a–73b), Book II of the *Physics* (196a–197b), and Book I of the *Metaphysics* (all), Aristotle states his position on causation and on the theory of necessity. His position is maintained consistently, so for convenience we can examine the version of it offered in the *Physics*. We begin with the second chapter of Book II, where there appears an almost perfunctory acknowledgement that things can be said to be understood only when their causes are known. Aristotle offers the distinction between knowing *that*, and knowing *why* (194b), and then goes on to discuss the different senses in which we say we know the “why” of an event. There are four general senses of “why” in the explanations we offer, and these can be illustrated by explaining a statue, say, Bernini’s “Fountain of the Rivers”:

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1. If we examine a statute, there is a sense in which we attribute the cause of it to the substance of which it is made, for example, stone. Here, we have what Aristotle referred to as the “material cause.”
 2. The difference between a lump of stone and a statue is that the latter has a certain form; not any single uniform one, but one that is not random. If we refer to this as the cause of the statue, we are invoking the Aristotelian notion of a formal cause. The same is true when we answer questions such as, “Why is the sum of the angles of a triangle 180 degrees?” The answer is that a triangle is defined as a figure containing 180 degrees; that is its essence, or its “formal cause.”
 3. Returning to the statue, one might attribute the cause of it to the changes produced by the hammer and chisel. Blow by blow, these changes lead to the finished work. A causal explanation based upon these actions expresses what Aristotle called the “efficient cause.”
 4. But if we stand in the Piazza Navona and ask someone the cause of the “Fountain of the Rivers,” it is not likely that the reply will include references to stone, or definitions, or hammering. More likely a one-word answer will be given: Bernini. The cause of these statues is the sculptor’s vision or genius: that which he intended even before selecting the stone, the site, or the cutting tools. In this sense, the cause of the “Fountain of the Rivers” is the goal or end of the artist.

This last is what Aristotle referred to as the “final cause.” The concept of final cause is the teleological element in Aristotle’s theory of causation and the element that medieval theologians and philosophers exploited in giving Chris-

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tian belief a scientific cast. Science, at least since the influence of David Hume (see Chapters 7 and 10 below), has been more or less confined to the study of efficient causes, appraising any form of teleological explanation as "metaphysical," if not superstitious. Nevertheless, we must contend with final causes here, as, indeed, we must in nearly every walk of life, even in experimental science, which also is understood in terms of its goals and purposes. Indeed, as long as we hold ourselves and others responsible, we are accepting an Aristotelian notion of final causes. The cause of a praiseworthy or blameworthy actions is taken to be an ulterior goal or purpose. The goal itself need not be good in some objective or unarguable way. It is sometimes alleged that Aristotle's final cause refers only to good intentions, but he makes it clear in a number of places that the final cause, the "that for the sake of which something is done," may be good or only apparently good (*Nicomachean Ethics*, Book III, Ch. 4).

Aristotle reasoned that since final causes are common in the affairs of the human world—itsself part of nature—nature, too, then must possess final causes. On this account, birds build nests in order to care for their young, and elephants kneel in the presence of kings as a sign of respect. From a modern perspective, Aristotle may (again) appear naive. We are tempted to excuse him, in a patronizing way, for failing to realize that motives and intentions are themselves (efficiently) caused by immediately preceding agents. Bernini's vision, after all, can be traced back to his training, his religion, the price of stone, and so forth. But the Aristotle of *De Anima* and *Politics* was quite aware of "conditioning" and "behavior modification" and surely would have argued that these are irrelevant to the issue. The issue is not how a given goal or intention was established. Rather, the issue or proposition is that outcomes are never completely understood until the final cause is apprehended, no matter what "caused" the final cause. That we may be "conditioned" to prefer Bach to Berlioz does not eliminate the fact of the preference. Without laboring over the virtues and vices of teleological explanations, one need only examine a modern discussion of embryological development or evolutionary theory or cosmology to ascertain whether science has eliminated final causes from its conceptual apparatus.

Aristotle invokes teleology but resists necessitarian theories. The latter cannot account either for error or for genius. All events will seem necessary until exceptions are noted. And, by denying purpose, the necessitarian will have to find the ship in the wood: that is, without the shipbuilder. Eventually the necessitarian and the teleological propositions merge. Whether things are as they are by necessity or by design, the ultimate outcome is never in doubt. We may not know what it is, but we can be sure, on either account, that it is. Thus, even in his *Physics*, with a lusty attack on necessity, Aristotle laid the foundations for the coming age of Stoic resignation.

We are now able to return to the Aristotelian approach to conduct and to

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governance, an approach stripped of many of the Platonic ingredients. In abandoning the necessitarian theory, Aristotle was able to advance the nativistic theory of virtue: "None of the moral virtues rises in us by nature" (*Nicomachean Ethics*, II, Ch. 1, 19–20). In its place is offered the empirist alternative: "We are made perfect by habit" (19–20). The perfection in question was the good defined as "activity of the soul in accordance with virtue" (19–20, I, Ch. 7, 1098a). Virtue in the Aristotelian system consists of intellectual and moral dispositions. The former is divided into philosophical wisdom and intelligence. The moral dispositions are those that conduce to liberalism and tolerance (I, Ch. 7, 1098a, 1103a). Both classes of virtue result from "study and care" (1099b) and from teaching, growth, and habit.

Aristotle even refers to the roots of the ethics in the word *ethos*, which means habit or an exercised skill (1103a). Opposing the central role given to the passions by members of the Academy, Aristotle insisted that all virtue is based on intention and choice, and that since acts impelled by passion are involuntary the passions do not figure in an account of virtue (1106a). This was one of the bases upon which he denied to nonhuman animals such virtues as courage and temperance. Behavior controlled by the passions lacks the element of rational. Nor was the patient with idle speculation as a putative form of virtue. The virtuous man is one who acts virtuously because he intends to; that is, virtue is his goal and is, therefore, the final cause of his behavior (1105b).

Consistent with this behavioristic criterion was Aristotle's conviction that actions aim at pleasure and avoid pain (1104b). This pattern is established in infancy and is therefore very difficult to alter (1105a). Only rigorous education can succeed in transforming pleasure-seeking into virtue-seeking conduct (Ch. 1, 179b–180a). Traces of Platonism can be found not only in the definition of the good as an accord between the soul and virtue (i.e., a kind of harmony) but also in Aristotle's emphasis on moderation. Virtue, he asserts, is "a mean between two vices" (1107a): excess and deficiency. The virtuous life is one guided by Aristotle's golden mean. Vice in the person and the State is invariably an expression of excess or deficiency and an extreme expression of that which in moderate degree is an absolute good. The good monarchy, transformed by excess, becomes tyranny; aristocracy becomes oligarchy; timocracy, in which political power is based on property, becomes democracy (1160b).

The Aristotelian Legacy

No figure from antiquity until the seventeenth century would be as important to the history of psychology as Aristotle. His most general contribution was to locate the intellectual and motive features of mind in the natural sciences, while reserving the moral and political dimensions of human life to a much enlarged conception of nature itself. At the level of basic processes, his psychology was

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biological and ethological, grounded in considerations not unlike those which Darwin would develop centuries later. If his own version of empiricism did not go so far as to submit scientific truths merely to confirmation by the senses, it did establish the validity and importance of the world of sense. In the process, Aristotle presented the senses themselves as objects of study.

In this same empiricist vein, Aristotle proposed the first laws of learning, loosely drawn around the principle of association and fortified by principles of reinforcement. Except for his retreat toward a somewhat fatalistic hereditarianism in the *Politics*, he consistently emphasized the part played by early experience, education, practice, habit, and life within the *polis* itself in the formation of the psychological dispositions. In this way, he presented human psychology as a developmental subject whose parent-science was at once civics and moral philosophy.

Aristotle's influence on science in general has aroused much speculation, and it was to some extent mixed. Subsequent scholars invested his works with unchallengeable authority for which, of course, Aristotle is not to blame. He promoted a rationalistic attitude in those who would seek the first principles of things, and on this the history of science must vindicate him. But this orientation soon was extended to matters that Aristotle himself treated empirically and understood to be beyond the reach of logical certainties. His ethical teaching refers to conditions and propositions that obtain "in general," "more or less," and "for the most part." Though persuaded that the moral and political terms of life are to be governed by universal principles, he still appreciated the complexities of life and the resulting inability to impose certainties on it in advance. Although his doctrine of final causes became a central theme in religious controversy, his four-fold theory of causation was of indisputable value to generations of scientists. And, on a loose reading, even the final causes are not alien to theoretical science as long as they are theologically neutral.

Aristotle lived at the end of Greece's classical approach, and his works are a fitting tribute to the names that made this age what it was. And what it was in fact, was nothing short of the birth of Western civilization. Aristotle labored to assemble and dissect all that was known and knowable. Had his effect upon us been less, we would not be so proud to discover his errors. It may be true, as one critic has insisted, that "practically every advance in science, logic, or in philosophy has had to be made in the teeth of the opposition from Aristotle's disciples."²¹ But neither science nor logic nor philosophy is easily conceivable without him.

We might join in the criticism of his political writings as departing not only from a healthy empiricist outlook but as sanctioning the cruelest forms of subjugation and elitism. Consider only his comments about "natural slaves" and women. What is often less scrupulously noted, however, is the place of his *Politics* in the development of that very constitutionalism by which liberties

have been won and preserved. In both the *Politics* and the *Nicomachean Ethics* he struggled to balance the rights of the citizen and the needs of the State. The particular balance he achieved depended, of course, upon the view he held of essential human nature and the State's essential function. In considering persons to be innately rational, inquisitive, and social, he was given to believe that discipline, self-sacrifice, and principled authoritarianism would find universal endorsement. Only those lacking reason (e.g., the "natural slave," children, the insane) would rebel. Aristotle was undeviating in his support of a society ruled by law, but this law itself was ruled by an ethics whose first principle was the welfare of the citizens, understood in terms of their realizing their full human potentials. It is this interconnection of society, law, ethics, and the public good that comprises constitutionalism and that installs Aristotle's psychology as perhaps the most integrated and systematic ever developed.

Stoic and Epicurean Psychology

As a general introduction to the post-Aristotelian philosophies, it is worth noting that debts to Aristotle are to be found nearly everywhere in them, including those parts devoted to critiques of Aristotle. J. R. Rist, in his *Stoic Philosophy* (1969), has observed that the very phrase "post-Aristotelian" really should be taken as referring to philosophies dominated by Aristotle's works.

In the previous chapter we noted the pre-Socratic interest in the physical properties of the world and contrasted this interest with the value-oriented philosophy of Socrates and his disciples. The pre-Socratics of Ionia developed their philosophical systems in a climate of commerce and growing prosperity. Socrates and the Academy of Plato flourished in the aftermath of the humiliating Athenian defeat at the hands of Sparta. While we must resist the allure of mechanical laws of causation in history, we must also acknowledge the regularity with which materialistic philosophies prosper in periods of empire and spiritualistic-idealistic philosophies emerge in the wake of destruction. With notable exceptions, intellectuals are apologists as well as critics, and so-called systems of thought are very often little more than rationalizations of the prevailing facts of life. The influence operates in both directions: political and economic forces affect the character of philosophy, and the latter works to maintain or modify those outlooks and institutions that define a period.

The major spokesmen for Stoic philosophy were Zeno of Citium (Cyprus), who lived between 336 and 265 B.C., and, both from Asia Minor, Cleanthes (ca. 331–ca. 232 B.C.) and Chrysippus (ca. 280–ca. 206 B.C.). Later Stoics of the Christian era include Seneca (ca. 4 B.C.–A.D. 65), Epictetus (ca. 50–ca. 138 A.D.), and Emperor Marcus Aurelius (121–180 A.D.). Epicurus (341–270 B.C.) was born on Samos and, although his parents were Athenians, his early education was received in Asia Minor from teachers versed in the philosophies

of Plato and Democritus. His most famous spiritual descendant was the poet Lucretius (99–55 B.C.), whose *De Rerum Natura* set to verse the tenets of Epicurean thought.

Although it is true that Stoicism and Epicureanism were rival philosophies, the two shared several characteristics of note, especially in their earliest development. Both were moved by the need to answer the increasingly influential schools of the Cynics and Skeptics. These were the schools that elevated Socrates' modest admission of ignorance to metaphysical heights and fashioned the cleverest of arguments to prove that nothing can be known about anything. Thus, the initial motivation for both Zeno and Epicurus was grounded in this need to restore philosophy to respectability. Then, too, although Stoicism throughout its history never took on the radical materialism of the Epicureans, both systems were based upon a natural-science perspective which, with reservations, may be called *physicalism*. Both were monistic philosophies in that they conceived of the universe as being ultimately reducible to a single agency, force, element, or "stuff." For the Epicurean it was atomic; for the early Stoics, something akin to fire or ether. The Stoics often referred to this "creative fire" as *logos* and thought of the divine in the same physicalistic terms. *Logos*, which might be translated as "word" (as in, "In the beginning was the word") or "plan," also lends itself to a meaning or "point," as in "the very point of something."

Both the Stoic and the Epicurean philosopher tended also to be committed to the development of an all-inclusive system of philosophy whose basic principles were as applicable to physical phenomena as to those arising out of political and moral concerns. Where the Socratics tended to ignore the material world and focus on abstract problems in epistemology and ethics, and where Aristotle had liberated his political and moral theories from the exact sciences, morals, and politics, Stoicism and Epicureanism treated such boundaries as artificial.

But this perspective needed a favorable climate to make progress. Democritus (c. 460–370 B.C.), an influential contemporary of Plato's, had tried to promote a radical, materialistic philosophy in the years following the Peloponnesian ordeal. He was one of the fathers of atomism, teaching that all of nature was no more than aggregations of particles of matter distributed in infinite space. At the time, Democritus was considered a skeptic. His failure to be taken seriously by the Socratics was not due to his being provably wrong, but to his being provably irrelevant. The fundamental challenge to the Athenian philosopher from 404 to 350 B.C. was to explain the demise of Athenian power and to lay the groundwork for Athens' rebirth. Atomism, in this setting, was useless. But by 300 B.C. the world had neither a use for nor ready exemplars of the Platonic "ideas," or true forms. Alexander was the first bona fide potentate of the West and was followed by men of even greater organizational talent. From

300 B.C. to the first century of the Christian era, the Western world was imperialist. Its defining ethic was expansionism. Its language, accordingly, was the language of law, administration, and finance. The voices of philosophy that spoke for this period are those of the Stoics and the Epicureans.

★ Epicurean philosophy begins with a psychological claim: that all knowledge originates in sensation. Aristotle would not reject this, though he would also not have meant the same thing by it. For Epicurus, the material organization of the body is such that experience becomes recorded in memory and can be revived in the form of concepts. By association, these concepts come to stand for the items originally given in experience. Thus, the frequent pairing of an actual apple with the word "apple" results in the expectation (*prolepsis*) of an apple when the word is heard. Since our only mode of verification is experience itself, questions regarding the truth or validity of experience are meaningless. All experience is the outcome of interactions (collisions) between material entities, between the matter of the world and the matter of the sense organs. Random collisions can produce random outcomes, as disease can produce pathological outcomes. Nevertheless, the properly functioning sense organ responds to what is there. The soul itself is a type of material organization made up of common elements (fire, wind, and air) and a fourth unnamed element that makes it possible for stimulation to be distributed over and within the body. This last element is the most subtle, but is material nonetheless. As a result of its activity, we have the capacity for pleasure and for pain. The business of life—the very preservation of life—centers on these facts and functions.

Those who set out to keep pain to a minimum will necessarily forgo any number of pleasures. They will abide by the laws to avoid punishment and will do what is "right" to garner praise. However, it is prudent for them to remove themselves from those political and social arenas in which the likelihood of frustration, danger, and disappointment is great. Happiness, it turns out, is tranquility, the absence of turmoil (*apatheia*) secured by friendship, moderation, and the abandonment of vain ambition. Human life is but a brief episode in the eternal history of atomic collisions. As with all other forms of being, this life reflects simply one of the infinite number of possible atomic configurations. In infinite time, all possible configurations come into being at least for the moment. (Hence, the Epicurean conviction that there are other worlds not much unlike our own). In the circumstance, the only prudent goal of life is to derive whatever pleasures the interval affords, and to exercise that degree of moderation consistent with the minimizing of pain and suffering.

How different from this is the Stoic outlook? In details, the two systems are sometimes radically opposed. The Stoic is committed to the view that a rational principle (the *logos*) guides the universe, while the Epicurean holds that the entire affair is statistical. In this same connection, the major Stoics subscribed to a cyclical theory of universal history; a theory of endlessly repeated phases

of creation and dissolution proceeding from the life-producing principle (*logos spermatikos*) of the universe. The Epicureans, of course, found nothing in experience to confirm such a view. And, since the Stoics found this rational principle expressed in human life, they concluded that each person has a duty (*kathēkon*) to promote the cause of reason in the affairs of society and State. This, we note, is a duty the Epicurean could well live without.

But at a broader level, the similarities between the two become rather more apparent, as does the source of their appeal to the ancient Roman world. Both finally conduce to a life of order, harmoniousness, civility, and modesty. Both lay the groundwork for this ethics in a cosmological theory based upon physical laws. In this way, both present nature as the model for life and for government. Even in the details of their respective psychologies, the Stoic and Epicurean display as much agreement as rivalry. Knowledge on the Epicurean account begins with sensation. On the Stoic account it also begins as the mental image (*phantasia*) of the sensory event. Both subscribe to a form of associationism, and both propose that elementary sensations give rise to general concepts (*katalepseis*). Indeed, in attempting to establish the criteria of validity for our perceptions, the Stoics often advocated a kind of statistical test based on clarity and utility. They did not go as far as to claim that nature itself was statistical in its operations, as the Epicureans did, but they were often content to accept that our knowledge of nature did not rise above the level of probability.

Central to Stoic thought, of course, is an ethics of rationality; an ethics pitting the emotional side of life against the powers of reflection and self-control. Even the word *pathos*, which might generally be taken to refer to a passion or emotion, was generally intended within Stoic contexts to be regarded as a kind of *disease* of the soul, or something on the way toward psychopathology. Plato and Aristotle had both emphasized the nature of the tension between rational and impulsive forces. Aristotle, however, recognized that both were part of the very nature of animal life and that what finally mattered for rational creatures was how they are disposed to express the passions. The Greek for "disposition" is *hexis* (pl. *hexeis*), and one may be said to have either a good or a bad *hexis* for, e.g., anger, love, etc. One's very character is expressed to a considerable extent by one's disposition (*hexis*) toward expressing a given emotion (*pathos*). It is with Stoicism that this line of argument concludes with a renunciation of emotion itself! Here again the Stoic and Epicurean movements of thought become ever more congruent, even if the foundational arguments differ.

What remains, in light of the foregoing, is the issue of materialism as one that would seem to make Stoic and Epicurean psychologies incompatible. We should note first that Zeno himself was credited with something of a materialistic psychology by ancient commentators and that the transcendental features of Stoicism come somewhat later in its development. But this is beside the

point. Rather, the issue of materialism is far more important to a comparison of Stoic and Epicurean cosmology and theology than it is to their psychological theories. That the Stoics argued in favor of a rational first cause, which the Epicureans generally denied, has no bearing on the fact that both took human rational capacities for granted. Similarly, both based their ethical canons on the quest for happiness. Epicurus and Lucretius were more explicit than Zeno in tracing pleasure and pain to our material organization, but both schools accepted the "pleasure principle" as entirely natural, and as ordained by the very laws of our nature. Thus, at a global level of analysis, early (pre-Christian) Epicurean and Stoic psychologies both present human mental life as something that takes the data of experience as primary, and from these data proceeds to form general concepts in such a manner as to organize conduct around the goals of happiness and harmonious contentment. For both, but in different ways, human nature is the mirror of nature and is to be understood in precisely the same terms employed in the description of nature.

The philosophies taught by Zeno and Epicurus in Athens came to have their greatest impact not on the Greek but on the Roman mind. Indeed, although these two philosophies evolved in Athens, they were not Athenian in their principal philosophical features. To be sure, each carried traces of Platonic and Aristotelian influence, particularly the Plato of the *Laws* and the Aristotle of the ethical treatises. Zeno and Epicurus were ethicists even more than they were natural philosophers. But unlike Aristotle, who succeeded in keeping physics and ethics apart, Zeno, Epicurus, and their disciples proposed a philosophical unity that had not been seen since the pre-Socratics. Their philosophies drew inspiration from nature such that government, reason, perception, and the entirety of the human enterprise were to be comprehended in terms of natural law. And human laws were to be patterned on this.

Though not Athenian, the Stoic and Epicurean philosophies do reflect the evolution of Greek theological attitudes which, as we have noted, were only gently touched by the Academy and the Lyceum. As Greek economy and philosophy evolved, so, too, did the Greek religious outlook. In *From Religion to Philosophy*,²² F. M. Cornford traces this evolution from the early Homeric period that found the gods obedient to destiny (*moira*) and at the mercy of chance (*lachesis*) to the Age of Pericles, by which time reason had replaced destiny and Zeus had arrogated to himself absolute power over the affairs of men and gods. In this same development, the earliest concept of law (*nomos*) as a dispenser (*nomeus*) of one's fair share or just proportion became transformed into the belief that the will of Zeus was itself the law of nature. Even from this all too superficial sketch of the changes that took place in the popular religious outlook from the sixth to the fourth centuries, we can discern the fundamentalist or revivalist tone of Stoicism. The Stoic philosophers saw their contemporaries as having wandered too far from the older and purer respect for *moira*,

lachesis, and *nomos*. While retaining the current emphasis upon the will, they insisted that its freedom was of a limited sort: we are free only as long as our will is reconciled to destiny and harmonized with the immutable *nomos*. As we see in the Vatican Fragments, Epicurus, too, urges that nature not be violated but obeyed (Fragment XXI); that we must not complain about what we lack but realize that all we have is the gift of fortune (Fragment XXXV); and that death is our common bond and shared future (Fragment XXX).²³ In this same tradition but four hundred years later, Epictetus (60–120 A.D.) summarized the central idea with that moving simplicity that identifies the Stoic mind:

Never say about anything, "I have lost it," but only, "I have given it back."²⁴

From its origin in the fourth century, Stoic philosophy struggled to foster a moral commitment while adhering to naturalism. Lucretius proposed conservationist laws of matter and momentum, and the Epicurean tradition rested its argument on the veracity of common sense and tutored perception. This same Lucretius, whose book attempts nothing less than an explanation of all that exists and occurs, can offer not a sentence of advice to Caesar and Pompey. He cannot tell us how to distinguish the just act from the unjust, nor can he discover any final cause of life other than the grave.²⁵ Even Marcus Aurelius, whose Stoic *Meditations*²⁶ were to teach us those principles of conduct and good taste that might bring some order to our lives, finally offers little more than a paean to quiet resignation.

It is often averred that Stoicism was in some way natural to the Roman mind, to the spiritual and political character of the empire. But Stoicism was a varied system whose major architects focused on different problems and wrote in different periods. Moreover, there are points of conflict not only among the Stoics but within the writings of a given spokesman. Still, each one does reveal a side of Roman psychology, and we will benefit from a review of the connection between Stoic thought and the facts of Roman life.

The popularity of the early Stoics in Rome is explicable in terms of the dominant feature of the Roman epoch, law. Law, if it is to rise above the mere threat of reprisal, must be principled. It must make daily and intelligible contact with what the citizen believes to be right and wrong. As a form of constraint, it must justify itself in terms of a higher good. The dilemma facing the Roman of the third and second centuries B.C. was no less than the conflict between historic moral restraint and sudden opportunities for colossal wealth. Rome, in its religion and society, had asserted the virtue of a quiet and conservative republican life. As a limitless empire, however, Rome made the goods and resources of the entire world accessible to the crafty and acquisitive citizen.

In focusing on the reflection of the cosmic *logos* in human rationality, the Stoics came to regard the human community as a breed apart. It is with Stoic

philosophy that we begin to hear about “human rights”—moral or political options inherent in human nature by virtue of its being *human*—and about the world as the common dwelling-place (*oikos*) of the community of rational beings. The universal brotherhood of Christianity is anticipated in this, as is the ever deeper separation between humankind and the natural world with its other precious inhabitants.

Epicurean materialism, on the other hand, could not accept a transcendent soul. Rather, if the soul can affect the body, it must be because it is a kind of body itself and is thus destructible. Personal immortality, therefore, is out of the question, as is fear of punishment in the afterlife. Accordingly, our only concern must be with life as it is lived from day to day. The goal is happiness which, in the last analysis, is freedom from pain. Since the quest for fame and power and riches usually leads to frustration and grief, the recommendation is for moderation, for a rejection of passion itself and the recognition that the passionate state is a kind of madness. As with Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle, the Stoic and Epicurean both emphasized contemplation as the means by which true happiness is secured. Unlike Plato, the Stoics endorsed contemplation less for the good of an immortal soul than for comfort in a troubled life. Thus did the Roman aristocracy proceed to study philosophy with all the enthusiasm one brings to other pastimes. In their thirst for culture, they imported hundreds of Greek scholars and thereby furthered the cause of Hellenization. Cicero stamped Roman law with Stoic reasonableness (even as he criticized Stoic philosophy), and Nero traduced the lessons of Epicurus into a grotesque caricature. Situationism, ethical relativism, and materialism lent righteous complacency to periods of prosperity but left the Roman morally defenseless when more powerful forces began to dismantle the Empire. As Rome approached the peak of her achievement, Lucretius could observe: “[N]early everything men need for life lies right within their grasp and . . . existence is safe and sound.”²⁷ But two centuries later, when Augustan greatness had receded and the barbarians’ steps grew louder, Marcus Aurelius would look back over the entire epoch and explain:

Thou hast endured infinite troubles through not being contented with thy ruling faculty.²⁸

Notes

1. The definitive biography of Aristotle’s intellectual development remains Werner Jaeger, *Aristotle: Fundamentals of the History of His Development*, Clarendon Press, Oxford, 1934. Recent scholarship, however, has raised objections to Jaeger’s interpretive biography.

2. *Ibid.*, Ch. 1.

3. *Ibid.*, Ch. 2.

4. Aristotle, *The Protrepticus*, translated by Anton-Hermann Chroust, University of Notre Dame Press, Notre Dame, Ind., 1964.
5. Ibid., p. 9.
6. Ibid., p. 44.
7. Ibid., p. 31.
8. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, Ch. VII, Sec. II.
9. Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, Book A (I). Parenthetical numbers refer to the line of text in the Greek. These numbers are conventionally employed in all translations.
10. Ibid. Book XIII, 4, 30–33.
11. Ibid.
12. Aristotle, *De Somnis*, Ch. I, 459b; Ch. 3, 462b.
13. Aristotle, *Posterior Analytics*, especially Book II, Ch. 19.
14. Aristotle, *Categories*.
15. Aristotle, *History of the Animals*, Book VI, Ch. 3, translated by A. L. Peck. Harvard, Cambridge 1970.
16. Aristotle, *On the Heavens*, Book II, Ch. 14.
17. Plato, *Theaetetus* (186), in *The Dialogues of Plato*, translated by Benjamin Jowett, Random House, New York, 1937.
18. Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, 1153b.
19. Aristotle, *Rhetoric*, 1389a–1389b.
20. Aristotle, *Politics*, 1252a.
21. Bertrand Russell, *History of Western Philosophy*, Simon and Schuster, Clarion Books, New York, 1945, p. 202.
22. F. M. Cornford, *From Religion to Philosophy: A Study in the Origins of Western Speculation*, Harper and Row, Harper Torchbooks, New York, 1957.
23. A collection of Epictetus's *Fragments*, reprinted from the Vatican Fragments, appears in *The Stoic and Epicurean Philosophers*, edited by Whitney Oates, Random House, The Modern Library, New York, 1940.
24. Ibid., Epictetus.
25. Lucretius, *De Rerum Natura*, translated by Palmer Bovie, New American Library, Mentor Books, New York, 1974.
26. Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*, in *The Stoic and Epicurean Philosophers*.
27. Lucretius, *De Rerum Natura*, Book VI.
28. Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*.

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Patristic Psychology: The Authority of Faith

Dark Ages?

The period covering the decline of classical Roman civilization and the emergence of the Christian world in Europe includes within it an allegedly “dark” episode of unbridled superstition and paralysis of intellect. We must be wary of that Renaissance habit of treating everything separating their own time from classical Greece and Rome as “dark” and “medieval.” Whom do we find when we thumb the pages of these centuries? Epictetus, Origen, Plotinus, Porphyry, St. Jerome, St. Augustine, Boethius, St. Anselm, Peter Abailard (Abe-lard), Robert Grosseteste, Roger Bacon, Thomas Aquinas, William of Ockham—this is the short list. And amidst their writings and achievements we also note the veritable invention of the university as we know it; the construction of more than a hundred “Gothic” cathedrals, each an architectural masterpiece; and the codification and promulgation of Roman law, modified to meet local conditions and laying the foundations for a unified culture and civilization. Not too dark, then, after all.

True enough, from roughly 500 to 800 A.D. the lamps of comprehension and genius are dim, the record of enduring accomplishment almost vanishingly thin. If there is a culprit to be named here, however, it is not the orthodoxies or superstitions of a Christian church but the utter collapse from within, and assaults from without, of all that was Roman civilization. During the early Christian era the cities were politically corrupt, financially and morally wayward. The now deified emperors were of a generally sorry character. Their official biographers provided the *Scriptores Historiae Augustae*, a lasting testimony to those special inanities bred by absolute power. For much of the time Athens was still the target of the philosophical pilgrim and Greek was the language of the learned. By the reign of Justinian, however, it had become a dead language in Rome, another sign of cultural collapse. A surer sign, however, was the contagious *nostalgia* expressed by the better minds of the period.